

DSST289: Introduction to Data Science — Taylor Arnold — Fall 2025

Website: <https://taylor-arnold.github.io/courses/dsst289-f25>

Topics: Methods for collecting, manipulating, visualizing, exploring, and presenting data.

Format: The semester is broken into four units, with an exam at the end of each. The last week of the semester is dedicated to a final project. Class meetings are hands-on and interactive. Please bring a computer, pencil, and something to write on to each class. Class materials can be found on the course website.

Reading & Class Form: Most class meetings will have a short reading posted on our website. We will fill out a brief class form each meeting, which is used for attendance and to pledge that you have done the reading. A class form grade will be given by subtracting 5% from your grade of 100% for each missing form after the first two (in other words, you have two excused missing forms).

Software: We will be programming in the open-source Python programming language. Classwork can be run through Google's Colab environment in a web browser using a University email login. Other hardware and software may be used for some data collection tasks; all of will be provided or freely accessible.

Exams: There are four midterm exams. Each will have an in-class component. Some exams, particularly the final one, may be an additional take-home component due on the day of the exam. A list of topics for each exam will be posted on the course website.

Final Project: A final project will be due during the last week of class. The project will focus on finding or creating a new dataset and applying the techniques learned throughout the class to the analysis of it. Detailed instructions will be posted following fall break.

Getting Help: We will usually have time in class to answer questions about the course material. If questions arise outside of class, please feel free to send these by email. I am happy to schedule office hours for any extended questions or personal concerns. Because I know everyone has a busy schedule, I offer office hours primarily by appointment.

Final Grades: The three exams, final project, and class form grades are averaged (i.e., each contributes 1/6 of your grade). A letter grade is assigned as follows: A (93–100), A- (90–92), B+ (87–89), B (83–86), B- (80–82), C+ (77–79), C (73–76), C- (70–72), and F (0–69).